

Social media

With billions of users worldwide, social media platforms are an exciting way for teens to stay in touch and connect, to entertain themselves, to organize and plan events, and to learn about the world around them.

Using social media

Understanding how social media platforms work and knowing what they can do enables teens to stay safe and get the most from them. The primary purpose of a social media platform is to offer its users an easy, instant way of connecting with family and friends, and others around the world. Many sites also offer the ability to share ideas, images, and videos, and to react to and comment on content that everyone can see, generating further debate and interest.

SEE ALSO

Digital self	132–133 >
Cyberbullying	138–139 >
Staying safe online	140–141 >
Privacy	142–143 >

“The Internet is becoming the town square for the global village of tomorrow.”

Bill Gates, cofounder of Microsoft

▽ What can social media do?

New uses for social media are being developed all the time. Here are some of the main ways people use it, but there are many more.

Interact

There are many ways for people to interact on social media. Users can talk through private messages or in a way that others can see. Users can connect with people of similar interests and organize to meet up in the real world if they want to.



Share media

Many users share content, such as images, videos, and music, through social media, whether they made it themselves or someone else did. The user's friends can then comment on the content or share it. If something is popular, it can quickly be shared hundreds of thousands of times, known as “going viral.”



Arrange events

Social media allows users to organize events, often at short notice. These events could be anything from a birthday party to a homework club, or even a political demonstration. In this way, it functions like a digital message board that's tailored to each user's life.



Discover and debate news

News organizations post snippets of their stories on social media. Users can then share, comment on, and debate these stories, drawing them to the attention of others and thereby spreading news and debate more widely than traditional media might.

